“If a leader quotes Scripture, what he says must be true.”

✦ ✦ ✦

Where it often comes from

Respect for spiritual leaders, taught from childhood. Leaders who used Bible verses to demand obedience or silence questions. Experiences of spiritual abuse or manipulation. Not feeling confident enough to study the Bible yourself. Assuming that anyone who knows the Bible well must be using it rightly.

What Scripture teaches

Scripture is true, but it can be misused. Even the devil quoted Scripture to Jesus, taking verses out of context. Paul warned that men would rise up even within the church and distort the truth. Peter said some people twist the Scriptures to their own destruction. Jesus told us to recognize false teachers by their fruit. A verse quoted out of context, or used to control or harm, does not carry God’s authority.

> *“I know that after my departure, savage wolves will come in among you and will not spare the flock. Even from your own number, men will rise up and distort the truth to draw away disciples after them”* **(Acts 20:29–30)**.

Also see

> “He writes this way in all his letters, speaking in them about such matters. Some parts of his letters are hard to understand, which ignorant and unstable people distort, as they do the rest of the Scriptures, to their own destruction” **(2 Peter 3:16)**.

> “Beware of false prophets. They come to you in sheep’s clothing, but inwardly they are ravenous wolves. By their fruit you will recognize them. Are grapes gathered from thornbushes, or figs from thistles?” **(Matthew 7:15–16)**.

> “Now the Bereans were more noble-minded than the Thessalonians, for they received the message with great eagerness and examined the Scriptures every day to see if these teachings were true” **(Acts 17:11)**.

> “To the law and to the testimony! If they do not speak according to this word, they have no light of dawn” **(Isaiah 8:20)**.

Common self-statements

- He quoted the Bible, so I have to obey.
- I can’t question a leader who knows Scripture.
- If I disagree, I’m disagreeing with God.
- He knows the Bible better than I do, so he must be right.
- Using verses proves he’s from God.
- I’m not smart enough to check.

Common logical errors

- **Appeal to authority:** Accepting a claim because a leader made it with a verse attached.
- **Discounting yourself:** Assuming you cannot understand or check Scripture.
- **Overlooking context:** Accepting a verse without asking what it meant where it was written.
- **Fear-based thinking:** Avoiding questions because you fear being labeled rebellious.

Challenging questions

- Did the devil quote Scripture to Jesus? Was he right?
- Is this verse being used in its original context?
- What fruit do I see in this leader's life and ministry?
- Does this teaching line up with the whole Bible, or just one verse?
- Is Scripture being used to help me or to control me?
- What did Paul warn about leaders who distort the truth?
- Who else could help me look at this passage honestly?

Truth summary

> A leader quoting Scripture does not automatically make what he says true. God's Word is always true, but people can misuse it. I can respect leaders and still check what they say against the whole of Scripture, look at its context, and watch the fruit of their lives. God gives me His Word and His Spirit to help me discern.

Related Pearls topics

Click a topic to open it in the Pearls Scripture Search:

- Truth
- Scripture/Word
- Church
- Wisdom
- Dishonesty

Godly Counsel Lessons:

From the book *Godly Counsel* by Dr. Brian Campbell. Click a lesson to open it. You can read it on screen or print it.

- Truth
- Judgmental

Listen: Overcoming Anxiety

> **Overcoming Anxiety** · Dr. Brian Campbell · about 18 minutes

Each morning ask: "If I truly believed God's truth instead of this lie, how would I think, speak, and act today?"

✦ ✦ ✦

HOMEWORK · REPLACE AND REHEARSE

My Plan for Replacing "If a leader quotes Scripture, what he says must be true"

✦ ✦ ✦

Read through each section and **check the one that fits you best**. If none of them fit, write your own. One choice per section is enough. A truth you choose for yourself will stick better than one handed to you.

Name: _____ **Date started:** _____

1 How strongly do I believe the lie?

Rate it now so you can see your progress later.

"If a leader quotes Scripture, what he says must be true." I believe this _____ % (0 = not at all, 100 = completely)

2 My best question

The one question I will ask myself every time the lie shows up.

- ☐ Did the devil quote Scripture correctly?
- ☐ Is this verse used in its original context?
- ☐ What fruit do I see in this leader?
- ☐ Does this fit the whole Bible?
- ☐ Is Scripture being used to help me or control me?
- ☐ Who could help me study this honestly?

My own question: _____

3 My replacement truth

The statement I will say to myself instead of the lie.

- ☐ Scripture is true, but people can misuse it.
- ☐ I can check every teaching against the whole Bible.
- ☐ I can recognize teachers by their fruit.
- ☐ Questioning a leader is not questioning God.
- ☐ God helps me understand His Word.
- ☐ Respect for leaders does not mean blind obedience.

In my own words: _____

4 My Scripture

The verse that speaks most directly to me. This is the one I will memorize.

- [ ] **Acts 20:29–30**
  "I know that after my departure, savage wolves will come in among you and will not spare the flock. Even from your own number, men will rise up and distort the truth to draw away disciples after them."
- [ ] **2 Peter 3:16**
  "He writes this way in all his letters, speaking in them about such matters. Some parts of his letters are hard to understand, which ignorant and unstable people distort, as they do the rest of the Scriptures, to their own destruction."
- [ ] **Matthew 7:15–16**
  "Beware of false prophets. They come to you in sheep's clothing, but inwardly they are ravenous wolves. By their fruit you will recognize them. Are grapes gathered from thornbushes, or figs from thistles?"
- [ ] **Acts 17:11**
  "Now the Bereans were more noble-minded than the Thessalonians, for they received the message with great eagerness and examined the Scriptures every day to see if these teachings were true."
- [ ] **Isaiah 8:20**
  "To the law and to the testimony! If they do not speak according to this word, they have no light of dawn."

A verse I found myself: _____

✦ ✦ ✦

HOMEWORK · REPLACE AND REHEARSE

Practicing the Truth

✦ ✦ ✦

5 My practice plan

Everyone does the first three. Then pick one or two extra tools.

EVERYONE DOES THESE

- ☐ **Make my Truth Card** (below). Carry it and read it at least three times a day.
- ☐ **Memorize my Scripture** from Step 4.
- ☐ **Set reminders** to silently repeat my truth. Check one or more:
  - ☐ **A buzz:** my watch or phone vibrates every _____ minutes
  - ☐ **An everyday event:** every time I _____
  - ☐ **A visual reminder:** something I will see often, such as a sticky note on my mirror, my truth as the background picture on my phone, or a note on my car dashboard.

PICK ONE OR TWO THAT FIT ME

- ☐ **Context log:** When a verse is used to tell me what to do, write the verse and read the whole chapter around it.
- ☐ **My name in Scripture:** Rewrite my verse with my name in it and read it aloud each morning.
  *For example, Acts 17:11 becomes: "Now **Sarah** is noble-minded, for **she** receives the message with great eagerness and examines the Scriptures every day to see if these teachings are true."*
- ☐ **Gratitude journal:** Each night, write three things I thank God for.
- ☐ **Truth recording:** Record my own voice reading my Truth Card and verse, and listen in the car or on a walk.
- ☐ **Reading:** The "Truth" topic in Pearls.
- ☐ **Listening:** The Overcoming Anxiety audio by Dr. Brian Campbell. Tap to play.

6 My action step this week

Do one thing that tests the lie in real life.

- ☐ **Choose one verse a leader often quotes,** read the entire chapter, and write what it meant in context.
- ☐ **Read Matthew 4:1–11,** and write how Jesus answered Scripture misused with Scripture rightly used.
- ☐ **Talk with a different, trusted pastor or Christian counselor** about a teaching that has troubled you.
- ☐ **Write down the fruit you see in a leader's life** using Galatians 5:22–23 as a checklist.

What I will do: _____

When: _____

What the lie predicts will happen: _____

7 End-of-week check-in

Bring this page to your next session.

What actually happened: _____

What I learned: _____

The lie "If a leader quotes Scripture, what he says must be true": _____ % **My truth:** _____ %

Daily practice tracker

Day	Read my card	Said my verse	Used my reminder	One verse I read in context
Mon				
Tue				
Wed				
Thu				
Fri				
Sat				
Sun				

My Truth Card

THE LIE

~~If a leader quotes Scripture, what he says must be true.~~

THE TRUTH

_____

_____

GOD'S WORD

_____

_____

Copy onto a 3×5 card, or cut along the dashed line and carry it with you.

Prayer

Father, thank You that Your Word is true and trustworthy. Help me reject the lie that anything a leader says must be true if he quotes Scripture. Give me wisdom to read Your Word in context, discernment to see fruit, and courage to hold to Your truth. Protect me from anyone who misuses Your Word. In Jesus' name, Amen.

✦ ✦ ✦

Scripture quotations are from the Berean Standard Bible (BSB), which is in the public domain.